

multi-touch (the Microsoft Surface type), improving hand-writing and voice recognition, and generally promising to reduce your keyboard usage. However, is this enough?

In this space, we've previously told you about research projects that promise to bring *thought* computing to the desktop. Though this research is mainly targeted at improving the lives of paraplegic patients, computers have paralysed us all in some way or the other. We're lazier than we've ever been, and nothing is more appealing to our vivid imaginations than computing at the speed of thought. Besides, although touch is fun and might be practical for some applications, speech just isn't so.

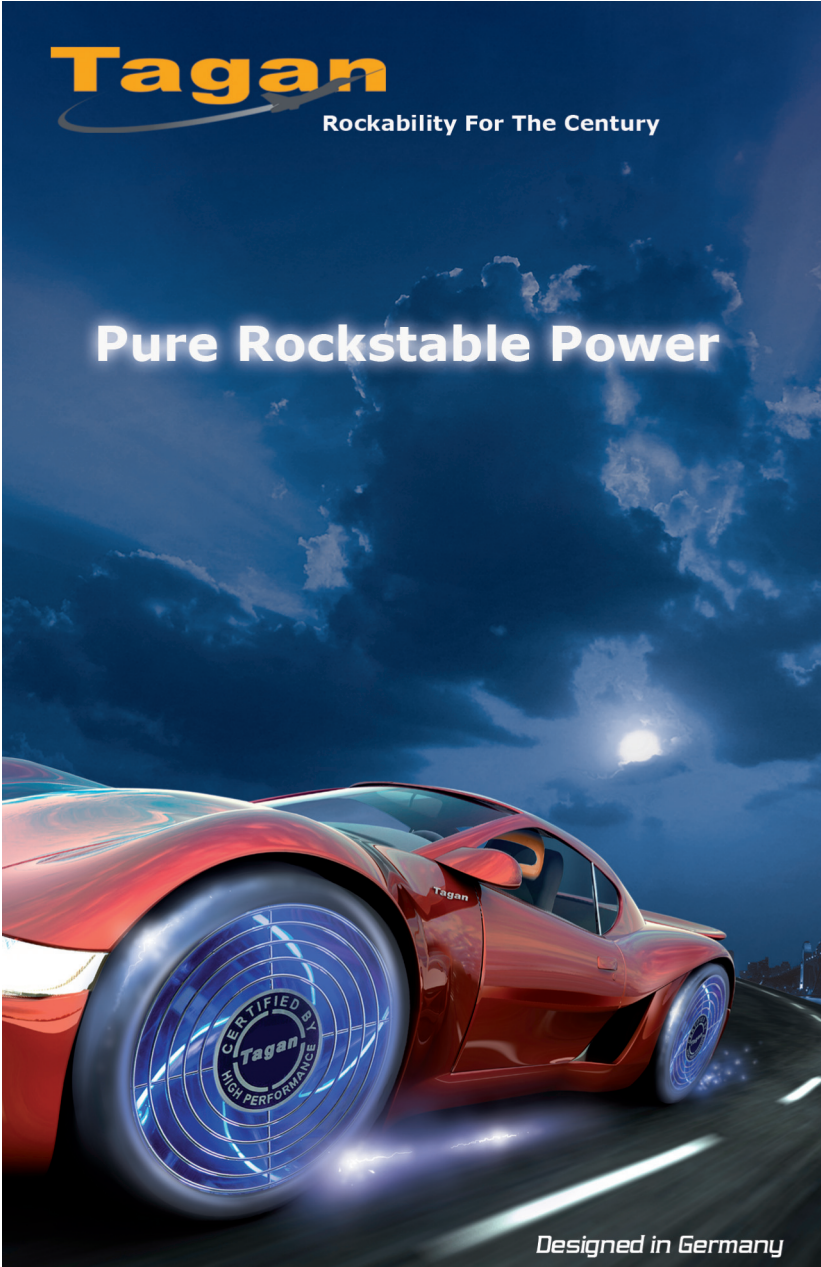
If we were all computing while sitting in a nice serene and silent corner of the planet, talking to your PC would not seem as stupid an idea. Reality, however, has us computing everywhere we are—while walking on the streets, travelling by car, rail or air, in the loo, on our beds, at work, at play... with all the noises of city-life about us, voice interfaces just start seeming idiotic. As if researchers didn't have it hard enough, what with trying to compensate for accents and pronunciations, trying to get a PC to recognise words over the din of traffic, or the bustle of metropolitan life is just near impossible. It's also against human etiquette and sense to submit to having to say, "Call mom" a few times to your phone, whilst invading the sonic space of everyone around, including yourself. For this reason, I personally don't see a future for speech recognition technologies in the OSes of the future. Touch, yes; Thought, yes please; speech, no thanks!

Trends

A year or two ago, there were rumours about "Google OS", or basically, plans from Google to launch a complete Internet-OS for those with always-on broadband access to the Net. Today, we're hearing rumours about Microsoft Research working on a product supposedly called Midori, which is a server-side OS, and basically will work just like we *thought* the rumoured Google OS would. What's more, it's rumoured that Midori aims to do away with platforms completely, so you can run it on a mobile, a PDA, a "netbook" (ultra-mobile PCs), desktops, and even as a process on any existing OS... you get the idea.

Is this the way forward though? Although opinions, as usual, vary from one extreme to the other, I personally think that a Midori-like OS is a very vital component in the future of OSes. Look at the trends, and you will get your answers. Everyone and his uncle already has a mobile device. By 2012, it's estimated that we will have half a billion mobile users in India alone. With flash memory prices falling, we're getting higher memory capacity gadgets and pen-drives. If 2 GB is the norm today, by 2012, we should have TBs in our systems, and at least 32 GB on our person at all times. Whether it's a flash drive, in your phone or your MP3 player, you will have a lot of data storage capacity.

It's already accepted that people in general, use more than one device or computer. You have your work computer, your mobile, computers you use in cyber-cafes, or your home computer/laptop. It makes sense that you would carry your data with you, and an Internet OS would let you do just that. With more computing devices than people who use them, it also makes sense to develop a digital persona, or an ID, so that you can be you, no matter what device you use. For this, obviously, you need an OS that's platform independent.



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